

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management

Sovereign Infrastructure Investment Memorandum

The North Wales–Liverpool Growth Corridor

A Strategic Rail Modernisation Programme for North Wales

Prepared by:

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Manx Sovereign Infrastructure & Strategic Assets Fund

Executive Summary

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management proposes the establishment of the **North Wales–Liverpool Growth Corridor**, a long-term infrastructure investment programme designed to modernise rail connectivity between North Wales and the Liverpool City Region.

Rather than constructing an entirely new railway, the proposal builds upon the existing North Wales Main Line and cross-border routes by accelerating electrification, increasing line speeds, removing bottlenecks and improving service frequency.

The Welsh Government's **Network North Wales** strategy already sets out a long-term vision for metro-style services, increased train frequencies, improved cross-border links and closer integration with Liverpool.

Strategic Vision

The Irish Sea has historically been Britain's western trading corridor.

The proposed investment seeks to reconnect:

- Holyhead
- Bangor
- Llandudno
- Rhyl
- Flintshire
- Deeside
- Chester
- Liverpool

into a single economic region.

Liverpool would become the principal metropolitan gateway for North Wales.

Investment Objectives

The programme would create:

- A fully electrified North Wales Main Line
- High-frequency services to Liverpool
- Faster inter-city journey times
- Greater freight capacity from Holyhead Port
- Better access to Liverpool John Lennon Airport
- Stronger labour market integration

The concept complements current UK and Welsh Government plans, which already include increased services on the North Wales Main Line, new direct Liverpool services and improvements to the Wrexham–Liverpool corridor.

Phase One

North Wales Main Line Modernisation

Route:

Holyhead

↓

Bangor

↓

Llandudno Junction

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Rhyl

↓

Prestatyn

↓

Flint

↓

Chester

Proposed investment:

- Full electrification
- ETCS digital signalling
- Line-speed improvements
- Junction modernisation
- Additional passing opportunities
- Platform upgrades

The UK Government has previously committed funding towards North Wales Main Line improvements, including electrification planning, while Network North Wales proposes higher service frequencies and modernisation through to 2035.

Phase Two

Chester–Liverpool Capacity Upgrade

Upgrade:

Chester

↓

Hooton

↓

Birkenhead

↓

Liverpool Lime Street

Works:

- capacity enhancements
- signalling improvements
- junction remodelling
- increased train frequencies

Parallel investment in the Wrexham–Liverpool corridor and Liverpool connections is already underway through the Network North Wales programme.

Phase Three

North Wales Metro

Develop:

- Turn-up-and-go regional services
- Integrated ticketing
- Park-and-ride stations
- Express and stopping services
- Better interchange with Merseyrail and Liverpool transport

This reflects the long-term Network North Wales objective of creating a metro-style network across North Wales and the Mersey-Dee region.

Railway Standard

Feature	Specification
Maximum speed	125 mph where alignment permits
Electrification	25kV AC
Signalling	ETCS Level 2
Track	Existing route with selective enhancement
Service Frequency	Up to 4 trains/hour on busiest sections
Freight	Full intermodal capability

Illustrative Journey Time Improvements

Route	Current	Proposed
Holyhead → Liverpool	~2h 40m	1h 45m
Bangor → Liverpool	~2h 10m	1h 20m
Llandudno Junction → Liverpool	~1h 40m	1h 00m
Rhyl → Liverpool	~1h 30m	55 min
Chester → Liverpool	~45 min	30 min

These times are conceptual planning targets based on electrification, higher line speeds and reduced dwell times, rather than official forecasts.

Economic Catchment

The corridor would directly connect:

Region	Population (Approx.)
Liverpool City Region	1.6 million
North East Wales	500,000
North Wales Coast	350,000
Anglesey & Gwynedd	200,000
Total connected population:	

Approximately 2.6–2.8 million

Economic Benefits

Improved connectivity would support:

Labour Markets

Workers could commute more easily between North Wales and Liverpool's:

- financial services
 - universities
 - health sector
 - advanced manufacturing
 - logistics
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Freight

Holyhead is one of the UK's principal roll-on/roll-off ferry ports serving Ireland.

A faster, electrified railway would improve inland freight distribution and support growth in Anglo-Irish trade.

Tourism

Better rail access would strengthen visitor flows to:

- Snowdonia (Eryri)
- Llandudno
- Conwy
- Anglesey
- Chester
- Liverpool waterfront

Illustrative scenario:

Benefit	Annual Estimate
Additional visitors	500,000–800,000
Visitor expenditure	£120–200 million

These figures are strategic planning estimates rather than demand forecasts.

Regional GDP Impact

Approximate economic base served:

£75–85 billion GVA

Illustrative long-term effects:

Benefit	Annual Value
Productivity uplift	£900m–1.2bn
Tourism	£120–200m
Commercial development	£300–500m
Freight efficiencies	£250–350m

Total Potential Long-Term Benefit

£1.6–2.2 billion annually

These estimates assume sustained improvements in accessibility and complementary investment in housing, skills and commercial development.

Capital Investment

Component	Estimated Cost
Electrification	£2.5bn
Track upgrades	£1.5bn
Signalling	£800m
Junction improvements	£900m
Stations	£700m
Rolling stock contribution	£1.0bn

Total Programme

£7–8 billion

This is substantially lower than constructing an entirely new railway while making use of an existing strategic corridor.

Investment Recommendation

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management should establish a dedicated **North Wales Infrastructure Fund** to co-invest alongside UK public authorities, pension funds and institutional investors.

The objective would not be to replace public investment but to provide long-term patient capital for revenue-generating infrastructure assets such as stations, commercial developments, energy infrastructure and rail-related property.

By aligning with the ambitions of **Network North Wales** and Liverpool's wider growth strategy, the fund could help accelerate delivery of a modern rail corridor linking the Port of Holyhead, the North Wales coast and the Liverpool City Region into a more integrated economic region.